Module 2 · Workbook answers

What is your identity?

Video: 52 min **Answer sheet**

This module asks the question that sits underneath every goal we set: who am I, really? Once you see that your true identity is your spirit, and that your body, mind, heart and soul are trusts you will one day hand back, life coaching becomes about returning those trusts in a better condition than you received them.

Answer sheet: the answers are in red. The reflection questions are personal, so your own answers will be in your own words and from your own life. These model answers show what the session teaches, to guide and check your thinking.

Key teachings

1 **From three values to one, and why we reflect Allah's attributes**

The session opens by narrowing the three values from Module 1 to two, then to one. This shows that your life already has good qualities, which should put your heart at rest, but also that choosing one value over the others is very hard. So rather than choosing our own values, it is easier to reflect Allah's attributes: the ones you picked (such as justice, Al-'Adl) may come naturally, but also seek those that do not, like love (Al-Wadud) or patience (As-Sabur). This applies to all of Islam, so worship is not mere ritual: we pray five times a day because Allah does not forget but we do; we give charity because our Lord is the Most Generous; we fast because Allah needs no food or drink, and neither drowsiness nor sleep overtakes Him. The speaker also links hijab to the veil (hijab) that will be lifted in Paradise so its people can see Allah.

2 **Why identity matters so much**

People wage wars over identity: they will kill other human beings over a nationality, a flag and a border, and how people are identified by gender can be deeply emotive. Identity matters because it gives us meaning, and meaning gives us purpose; without purpose, life becomes depressing. In the live session people described their purpose as to worship God, to gain His pleasure, to serve Him and to seek His mercy. Last module explained worship as getting to know the Creator through His attributes. Identity brings this home: if I know who I am, I know how to live out that purpose, and that is where we find peace.

3 **The false identities that leave us unfulfilled**

Many of us come to coaching because we are unclear on our identity. The employee dreams of being an entrepreneur and feels he has missed out, while the entrepreneur longs for a stable monthly salary (the speaker has felt both). The stressed mum, surrounded by toys, nappies and sleepless nights, wishes she had built a career, while the successful chief executive who never started a family has her own regret. When these become our core identities we can never fully optimise them, so we always feel something has gone wrong. The question is: is that really who I am?

4 **Are we just advanced animals?**

One theory says we are simply well-evolved animals, and we do share a lot with them: animals eat, drink, sleep, work, marry, raise and train their young, build homes and fight, and so do we. Ask the average person their goal in life and you often hear four things that animals also chase: possessions (a bird uses twigs, we use metal, and the new car turns out to be much like the old one), pleasure (travel, tasty food), praise (fame, like the alpha male who wins the group) and power (territory, which animals mark with urine). These drives are part of us, but there must be more. We want loftier goals.

5 **Your true identity is your spirit**

What makes us different is that we have the capacity to reflect Allah's attributes. Allah existed with His attributes, then created spirits able to reflect them, in a world of spirits ('alam al-arwah). Your core identity is your spirit. The spirits were gathered and took an oath with their Creator: "Am I not your Lord?" and we said, "Yes." The speaker teaches that this took place at Arafah, which is why every Muslim who is able must perform Hajj and stand at Arafah to remind themselves of it; without Arafah there is no Hajj. Scholars explain that we cannot remember the oath because it lives on as our fitrah (innate disposition) to believe in God.

6 **The four trusts**

Allah then offered the amanah (trust) to the heavens, the earth and the mountains; they declined, and the human being took it on. We were given four trusts, and in each we have full choice over how we use it. (1) The body, our physical self. (2) The mind, our intellectual self: no animal comes anywhere near human language, medicine, mathematics or philosophy. (3) The heart, our moral self and character: a hungry lion that eats a baby is not evil, but a human who did so would be. (4) The soul, our emotional self, called in Arabic the nafs. People get lost when they take the body as their identity, making things like gender all-important, when the body is a temporary trust.

7 **Handing the trusts back**

This is the epic story of every one of us: from the world of spirits, the oath and the trusts, we were sent to earth, and one day we must hand the body, mind, heart and soul back. Imagine being lent a top-of-the-range Rolls-Royce, spotless with no dents; death is handing back the keys. The Prophet ﷺ told us to remember death often and called it the destroyer of pleasures. We can return the trusts in a terrible state (eating anything and everything, never working on our character because we chased the wrong identity) or in a better state than we received them. That is what life coaching is really about: optimising the body, mind, heart and soul.

8 **Start with the body, and start with the tongue**

To make this practical, begin with the body and its main organs: the eyes, tongue, ears, hands, stomach, private parts and feet. In 2016 the speaker woke up blind in his right eye; in hospital he vividly asked himself whether he had used his eyes in the right way, and felt accountable for every choice (his sight later returned). The best place to start is the tongue, as several hadith show. Whatever your circumstances, whether you have a job or not, children or not, even if you are blind or disabled, you can reach a high spiritual status by reflecting Allah's attributes through what you do control, step by step.

From the Qur'an, the Sunnah and the scholars

وَإِذْ أَخَذَ رَبُّكَ مِنۢ بَنِىٓ ءَادَمَ مِن ظُهُورِهِمْ ذُرِّيَّتَهُمْ وَأَشْهَدَهُمْ عَلَىٰٓ أَنفُسِهِمْ أَلَسْتُ بِرَبِّكُمْ ۖ قَالُوا۟ بَلَىٰ ۛ شَهِدْنَآ ۛ أَن تَقُولُوا۟ يَوْمَ ٱلْقِيَـٰمَةِ إِنَّا كُنَّا عَنْ هَـٰذَا غَـٰفِلِينَ

And [mention] when your Lord took from the children of Adam - from their loins - their descendants and made them testify of themselves, [saying to them], "Am I not your Lord?" They said, "Yes, we have testified." [This] - lest you should say on the Day of Resurrection, "Indeed, we were of this unaware."

Surah Al-A'raf 7:172

إِنَّا عَرَضْنَا ٱلْأَمَانَةَ عَلَى ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ وَٱلْجِبَالِ فَأَبَيْنَ أَن يَحْمِلْنَهَا وَأَشْفَقْنَ مِنْهَا وَحَمَلَهَا ٱلْإِنسَٰنُ ۖ إِنَّهُۥ كَانَ ظَلُومًا جَهُولًا

Indeed, We offered the Trust to the heavens and the earth and the mountains, and they declined to bear it and feared it; but man [undertook to] bear it. Indeed, he was unjust and ignorant.

Surah Al-Ahzab 33:72

وَمَا نَتَنَزَّلُ إِلَّا بِأَمْرِ رَبِّكَ ۖ لَهُۥ مَا بَيْنَ أَيْدِينَا وَمَا خَلْفَنَا وَمَا بَيْنَ ذَٰلِكَ ۚ وَمَا كَانَ رَبُّكَ نَسِيًّا

[Gabriel said], "And we [angels] descend not except by the order of your Lord. To Him belongs that before us and that behind us and what is in between. And never is your Lord forgetful."

Surah Maryam 19:64

> *The Muslim is the one from whose tongue and hand the Muslims are safe.*
>
> **Sahih al-Bukhari and Sahih Muslim**

> *Whoever guarantees me what is between his jaws and what is between his legs, I guarantee him Paradise.*
>
> **Sahih al-Bukhari**

> *Remember often the destroyer of pleasures: death.*
>
> **Sunan at-Tirmidhi**

Practical exercises

From three values to one

1. Write down the three values you chose in Module 1.
2. Cross out one, keeping the two that matter most to you.
3. Now keep only one. Notice how hard it is to let the others go.
4. Next to each value, write the name of Allah it reflects (for example Al-'Adl, the Just; Al-Wadud, the Most Loving; As-Sabur, the Patient).
5. Choose one attribute that does not come naturally to you, and write how you could start reflecting it.

Who am I, and what is my purpose?

1. Write, in one sentence, what you think your purpose in life is.
2. List the identities you most attach yourself to (for example employee, entrepreneur, mum, career, nationality).
3. For each, ask honestly: has this left me feeling I have missed out?
4. Rewrite your purpose starting from "My true identity is my spirit, so..."

A plan for the body's trusts

1. List the main organs: eyes, tongue, ears, hands, stomach, private parts and feet.
2. For each one, write how you are using it in your day-to-day life at the moment.
3. Imagine you lost one of them tomorrow. Would you be happy with how you used it?
4. Write one change for each organ that would help you hand it back in a better condition.
5. If this feels like too much, do it for the tongue only. We will look at each organ in detail next session.

Watch your tongue this week

1. Each evening, think back over what you said today.
2. Note one moment you used your tongue well (a kind word, thanks, remembrance of Allah).
3. Note one moment you would take back (backbiting, harshness, complaining, lying).
4. Decide what you will say instead next time.

My week of guarding the tongue

Tick each day you practise.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Thought about my words before speaking							
Said something kind or grateful							
Avoided backbiting and harsh words							
Reviewed my words before sleeping							

Reflection questions and answers

1. When you narrowed your values down to one, which value was hardest to let go, and why?

> Narrowing three values down to one shows that your life already has good qualities, which should put your heart at rest, but also how hard it is to choose between them. That is why the session suggests reflecting Allah's attributes rather than choosing our own values, including the ones that do not come naturally. For example: "Patience was hardest to let go, because it is the one I most need, even though justice comes more naturally to me."

2. Which identity (job, role, nationality, appearance) do you lean on most, and has it ever left you feeling you missed out?

> The session describes identities that leave us unfulfilled: the employee who dreams of being an entrepreneur, the entrepreneur who longs for a steady salary, the stressed mum who wishes she had built a career, and the chief executive who never started a family. When a role becomes our core identity, we always feel something has gone wrong. For example: "My job title. When I was passed over for promotion I felt worthless, because I had made my work who I am."

3. Which of the four animal goals (possessions, pleasure, praise, power) pulls at you most, and where do you see it in your week?

> The four goals we share with animals are possessions, pleasure, praise and power. They are part of us, but we were made for loftier goals. A good answer is honest about where one shows up in an ordinary week. For example: "Praise. I check how many people liked my posts several times a day, and I feel low when the number is small."

4. What does it change for you to know that your true identity is your spirit, and that you once said "Yes" to "Am I not your Lord?"

> Your core identity is your spirit, created able to reflect Allah's attributes in the world of spirits. The spirits took an oath with their Creator, answering "Yes" to "Am I not your Lord?", and scholars explain this lives on as our fitrah (innate disposition) to believe in God. For example: "It reminds me that I am more than my job or my body. My worth comes from a promise I made to Allah, and I want to live up to it."

5. Of the four trusts (body, mind, heart, soul), which are you looking after least? What condition would you hand it back in today?

> The four trusts are the body (our physical self), the mind (our intellectual self), the heart (our moral self and character) and the soul, or nafs (our emotional self). In each we have full choice over how we use it, and one day we must hand it back. For example: "My body. I eat anything and everything and rarely move, so today I would hand it back in a worse state than I received it."

6. Think of someone you know who has passed away and handed back their trusts. What would you like said about how you handed back yours?

> The session pictures death as handing back the keys of a spotless Rolls-Royce you were lent, and reminds us that the Prophet ﷺ told us to remember death often, calling it the destroyer of pleasures. We can return our trusts in a terrible state or in a better state than we received them. For example: "I would like people to say I guarded my tongue, was patient with my family and worked on my character until my last day."

7. Whatever your circumstances, what is one thing fully in your control through which you can reflect Allah's attributes?

> Whatever your circumstances (with or without a job or children, even if you are blind or disabled), you can reach a high spiritual status through what you do control. The best place to start is the tongue: the Muslim is the one from whose tongue and hand the Muslims are safe. For example: "My words. However busy or tired I am, I can choose to speak kindly and avoid backbiting."

My action plan

- [ ] I will narrow my values down to one and link it to a name of Allah.
- [ ] I will remember that my true identity is my spirit, not my job, role or body.
- [ ] I will write a plan for how I use each organ of my body, starting with my tongue.
- [ ] I will check my words every evening this week.
- [ ] I will remember death, the destroyer of pleasures, at least once a day.
- [ ] I will bring my plan for the body to the next session.